defense posture vis-à-vis the north. Similarly, Washington's support for Taiwan should remain steadfast. Many nations in the region carefully watch the strength of American ties with Taiwan as an indicator of how far Washington will go to help Asian nations resist Chinese pressure. While Taiwan is admittedly a special case, nonetheless to abandon its thriving democracy not only would deliver a blow to stability in the region by encouraging China but would undermine US credibility as a political partner.

Working with Japan and Australia, the United States should continue to develop closer relations with India and with nations in Southeast Asia, particularly those with liberal political systems or those leaning toward liberalism. Though formal alliances with such nations are unnecessary, the more a viable community of interests is formed, the more likely it is that Washington will find political and even security support for its efforts to maintain a free and open Indo-Pacific. Countries such as India and Vietnam can be valuable partners in expanding regional maritime cooperation, which in turn can lead to closer political ties.

No small part of American strategy in Asia should be a fair free-trade area. Though the Trump administration withdrew from the Trans-Pacific Partnership, it or its successors should either consider rejoining the successor TPP 11 or come up with some viable alternative that begins linking largely free-market economies in a closer trading network. Some movement along these lines was indicated by new US trade talks with Japan during Trump's first term. Such agreements, even if smaller in scope than the TPP, will help offset the inroads that Beijing is making with its One Belt One Road initiative and the creation of the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank.

In promoting these policy ends, America will be protecting its own interests. These are under direct attack from a confident China that too often ignores its own problems, from a North Korea that seeks the means to threaten all around it, and from governments that are at risk of turning toward more authoritarian and confrontational policies. While supporting democracies and liberal ideas is not inherently